

are questions. |

| Project sprints and milestones | Inbound Marketing (inbound-mktg) uses the Geekbot Slack app to poll team members with the following questions: 1) Which project are you currently focusing on? 2) What went live/was completed since Tuesday? 3) What is this week's top 3 priorities? 4) Do you need help with anything that may slip? |

| Broadening coverage during PTO | Team members may assign a Channel instead of a Co-worker to cover for them when planning paid time off using Time Off by Deel. |

| Preparing for meetings or interviews | GitLab's PR teams (external-comms) prepare speakers async by sharing a Google Doc in advance with background on the topic, key messages to convey, relevant handbook and media links, meeting time and join links, session logistics, etc. |

| Editing communiques and content | GitLab's Content (content), Events (events), and Corporate Marketing (corp-mktg) teams routinely edit panel questions, session titles, company announcements, and pitches via Google Doc. Async feedback is given using the Suggesting feature in Google Docs and accurately tagging individuals with the Comments function. |

| Weekly team kickoff/standup sessions | Corporate Marketing (corp-mktg) uses the Geekbot Slack app to conduct weekly async standups with the following questions: 1) How do you feel today? Red/Yellow/Green 2) What did you do this weekend? 3) What are your priorities this week? 4) Anything blocking your progress? 5) Any upcoming paid time off (PTO)? |

| Missed deliverable retrospective | Engineering Package Group utilizes async deliverable retrospectives through GitLab issues labeled ~"group::package" |

| Blocked calendars and non-linear workdays | You are encouraged to block your work calendar to ensure that family and friends come first. This comes in many forms, from blocks to engage in fitness or meditation, to caregiving, to picking one's child up from school. These blocks force a non-linear workday, which reinforces that you may not be immediately available during these blocked times, and team members should engage with you asynchronously. |

| Alternate times for recurring scheduled meetings | Synchronous meetings should be inclusive of those who want to attend and are in different time zones. For example, a team's recurring weekly meetings, alternate between a time which is ideal for EMEA and Eastern AMER (8:00AM Pacific) and a time ideal for APAC and Western AMER (3:00PM Pacific). |

| Async communication with those who are not GitLab team members | It may be challenging to coordinate and communicate asynchronously with customers, business partners, community contributors, etc. who default to synchronous communication. To convey GitLab's async practices, share our All-Remote Asynchronous Guide in advance, and consider affixing it to calendar invites and agenda docs as well. It's important to be flexible, and educate others on the benefits of and processes for effective asynchronous communication. |

| Asynchronous engineering standup meetings | Standup meetings are commonly used by engineering teams to keep all team members apprised of what they were working on recently, what they plan to work on next, and if they need help on anything. Since GitLab operates primarily async, we use Slack channels and bots like GeekBot to communicate this in an async fashion. |

All are welcome to make a merge request to this page and add more examples of async integration.

Core behaviors/communications that should be async and structured

1. If you're seeking to collaborate or brainstorm via whiteboard, study how GitLab uses Google Docs as a remote whiteboard.
1. Proposals and thought-starters should be written down, so that feedback and consensus can be gathered quickly asynchronously by a wide group of people.
1. If you're asking for help or feedback from another team member(s), you should be willing to document the request in a GitLab epic, issue, or merge request with the appropriate context.

How to decline meetings in favor of async

Meetings are useful for building rapport and moving projects forward. They are also extremely costly and disruptive to flow. It's a shared responsibility to think twice before scheduling a meeting, as well as politely questioning meeting invitations.

Suggesting an asynchronous workflow over a meeting can feel uncomfortable. We want to ensure that all GitLab team members recognize this for what it is: a sincere attempt to move work forward in a more inclusive way, and not a personal slight. If you're invited to a meeting that may not need to exist, it's OK to respectfully decline and point GitLab team members back to this handbook section.

Below are a few sample regrets, borrowed from an excellent remote communications guide assembled by Dropbox.

1. "Thanks for including me! I'm wondering if we could try to solve this using a GitLab issue or merge request instead so our thoughts and progress is documented?"
1. "I've been in so many meetings lately, but I'm trying to be more disciplined about my schedule. Could we try to solve this without a meeting, first?"
1. "I'd be happy to give you feedback on that! Before we schedule a meeting, could I review it in a GitLab issue/merge request, or shared doc?"

If the team decides to go ahead with a meeting you can't make, consider assigning a delegate to represent you and contributing feedback/questions in advance in the agenda that should be attached to the calendar invite.

Best practices, guidelines, and async feature set

Asynchronous working is a feature set that supports and streamlines the variety of communication approaches, emphasizing comprehension and consideration, rather than prescribing a one-size-fits-all approach.

Teams should embrace a self-service mentality, single source of truth (SSoT) to fully understand the capabilities of asynchronous workflows, how GitLab (the product) facilitates asynchronous communication, and how to leverage existing tools (e.g. Google Docs) in an asynchronous manner.

GitLab team members may question meetings, suggesting an asynchronous alternative (e.g. discussing in a GitLab epic, issue, or merge request) to cover the topic of the meeting.

1. Conduct an asynchronous pilot. This could mean attending half of your weekly meetings async for a week and conducting a retrospective on the differences between sync attendance and async attendance.

1. Conduct a non-linear workday pilot. Consider shifting your schedule to better suit your peak productivity hours, caregiving hours, or experiment with alternative work schedules that would not be supported in rigidly synchronous organizations.
1. For any given piece of work, seek to optimize the mix of synchronous and asynchronous engagements for maximum efficiency and potential for iteration.
1. Team members have varying learning and communication style preferences (e.g. neurodiversity) that make audio discussion much more effective than written. Thoughtfully timed synchronous discussions ensure that everyone can contribute.
1. Every meeting should be a review of a concrete proposal or to catalyze a future series of asynchronous events, and only called when it will lead to a more efficient outcome than would be possible asynchronously.
1. An initial team-building sync at the start of a project or milestone can unlock a highly efficient follow-on series of asynchronous events. Be mindful to structure these initial syncs intentionally to build rapport and trust. The goal of gathering the group in a shared space should be unambiguous: it serves to equip team members with the context they need to switch primarily to asynchronous afterwards. Note that even these intentionally structured kickoff calls may not be inclusive of all time zones. Thus, it is important to adhere to GitLab's meeting guidelines, affixing a Google Doc agenda to the calendar invite, encouraging all parties to contribute textually if they cannot attend in person, and recording the full session for future viewing.
1. Do not use @-handles unless you are requesting a specific written action or piece of feedback from the person and you provide the proposal and context necessary for them to execute.
1. If a GitLab epic, issue, or merge request is over 1,000 words, a summary is required at the top of the issue/merge request for efficient absorption of key points.
1. Brainstorming or incubating ideas synchronously shouldn't be outright discouraged, though team members should be mindful to document takeaways as quickly as possible to prevent knowledge decay and to be inclusive of feedback from a wider group than those in the synchronous brainstorm session. Consider two songwriters who discover a spark for a new jingle, destined for glory in the GitLab Songbook. They may record a voice memo to capture the essence of the idea, then share that more broadly to refine and iterate on the song. A similar approach can be taken by documenting sparks in a GitLab merge request or issue, then shared in relevant Slack channels for added feedback.

Async survey data

GitLab team members were polled on 2020-09-02 in the public company-fyi Slack channel, with polling open through 2020-10-02. Roughly 20% of team members responded to the poll, with answers and percentage of replies outlined below.

Team members were asked: Why would you choose synchronous communication over asynchronous for work-related (e.g. not informal communication) discussions?

- I was unaware of GitLab's operating principle 'Bias towards asynchronous communication' - 1%
- I prefer verbal communication over written communication - 3%
- I believe the subject matter is confidential - 10%
- Someone else on my team can join and document the takeaways from a synchronous meeting - 1%
- I find it difficult to get others' attention via asynchronous communication - 12%
- It's useful to build rapport and catalyze future async conversations - 38%
- I don't feel that I have the tools, support, and/or training to rely on asynchronous in my

role - 0%

- It takes more time to set up an async communication for success that it does to schedule/conduct a meeting - 6%
- I find it hard to brainstorm or gather information when I operate async - 19%
- Other - 10%

Key learnings

Responses are open to interpretation, though the data provide key insights that GitLab leaders may use to better understand the dynamics of their teams and iterate on solutions.

1. While only 1% noted that they were unaware of an operating principle related to asynchronous communication, leaders should not assume that all operating principles are acknowledged and well-understood. Reinforce and discuss values in 1:1 meetings and day-to-day workflows.
1. GitLab is public by default. If you believe a matter is confidential, check this in the Not Public section of the Communication handbook.
1. If you find it difficult to get someone's attention via asynchronous means, consider leveraging a synchronous engagement to discuss potential gaps in expectations. While GitLab is articulate about where work happens, some team members work exclusively from GitLab's To-Do List or Scoped Labels and have varying approaches to prioritization (see Brand and Digital Design's Iteration Process handbook for an example). Assume positive intent, as delays in response may be attributable to putting family and friends first.
1. The majority of respondents indicated that they leverage synchronous engagements to build rapport and catalyze future async conversations. Having a meeting not because it's easy, but because it will create future efficiencies and cohesion, is a positive outcome.
1. It is encouraging that GitLab team members feel that they have the tools, support, and training to rely on asynchronous workflows. However, leaders should be mindful of new tools and practices that GitLab can pilot and surface these in the public values Slack channel. Iteration also applies to our approach to asynchronous communication.

GitLab experts advise on when to use sync vs async

1. "I use sync meetings to help others when an urgent matter comes up such as incidents or deadlines."
1. "I use sync mainly for troubleshooting where more live dialog is faster for all parties to solve the particular issue than async explanations and back and forth."
1. "I use sync when I have exhausted async options or async is not leading towards Results."
1. "I use sync meetings to generate creative ideas/proposals with my team that quite frankly would be difficult to do async."
1. "10 minutes on Zoom is more efficient than 100 Slack replies over a few hours or 10 days waiting for GitLab issue thread replies from tagged team members."
1. "For work-related, formal comms, I prefer async (and choose async when the format is up to me). Sync is great for relationship building (coffee chats, group social chats)."
1. "I enjoy sync to establish an initial human connection when team members have never met before (e.g. coffee/social/team calls)."
1. "If something is very time sensitive, I will opt for a sync meeting with all involved to have a quicker discussion."
1. "I tend to lead with async communication and then fall back on sync conversations when async fails. I view async communication to fail when time-sensitive topics aren't addressed efficiently or if I sense folks contradicting or talking past one another. In these situations,

I'll call a sync conversation to focus and force conversations to happen, then revert back to async once the conversation is essentially unblocked."

1. "Async works very well for detailed technical conversations, especially when linked to code. Sometimes it can take a couple of reads to conceptualise something and async is perfect for this. Async is also great for code reviews. For big picture discussions a combination of async and live/videocall is useful, but the results should be documented in the related GitLab issue for transparency. We sometimes use Google docs but GitLab are a better record, and are easier to search and comment on."

1. "I prefer to keep it async most of the time, but I'm also aware that as a Product Designer I need sync time during early stages in the design process to ensure I understand the problem and to brainstorm together with the team. After that, I find that async can be as efficient as sync, but only if everyone communicating puts in the effort in their written communication. It's important to include extra details and be extra careful about how you write to minimise the potential misunderstanding and need for back-and-forth."

1. "I handle most communications async, but found that the occasional sync meeting helps the entire product team come into alignment. Our sync sessions bring everyone to the table to discuss user research results, review designs, discuss implementations, etc. This rarer meeting helps keep everyone in alignment and helps the team's async structure flow more easily."

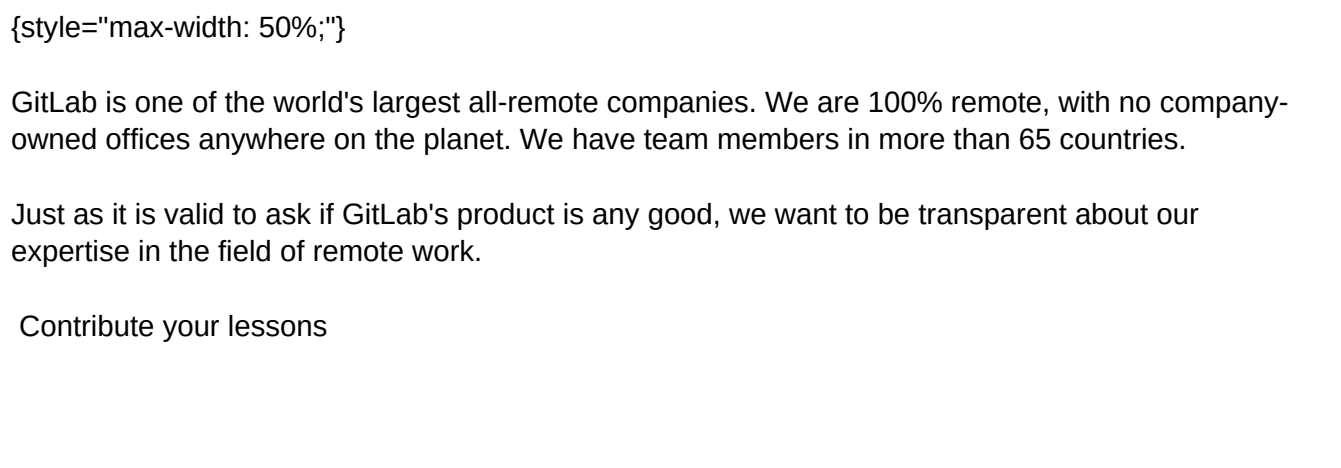
1. "For most cases I default to async communication. In general it is easier to trace back steps and reiterate on reasoning that lead to given decision. On rare occasions it is hard to share a given point of view. After several backs-and-forth on single matter I prefer to have short chat to get to the bottom of the issue, and document outcomes. Another exception where I prefer sync over async is the final brainstorm before making an important decision. In async communication, some matters appear too trivial to be asked about, while they may turn out to be important in the end. For such cases, after having a synchronous brainstorm as a final closing step, a retrospective or AMA session may be useful."

1. "I work with very technical concepts that are hard and time consuming (for me as a designer) to understand via async communication (especially written). It is more efficient to meet with a more technical colleague who can explain the tech details and purpose of a feature and who can answer questions on the spot. After I have a good understanding of the technical details I am more comfortable working async."

1. "During async communication, there's often a lot of context-switching that happens as you wait for someone to respond. It's sometimes necessary to have synchronous communication to make sure that you can move forward quickly."

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Embracing Asynchronous Communication

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation course . If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{style="max-width: 50%;"}


GitLab is one of the world's largest all-remote companies. We are 100% remote, with no company-owned offices anywhere on the planet. We have team members in more than 65 countries.

Just as it is valid to ask if GitLab's product is any good, we want to be transparent about our expertise in the field of remote work.

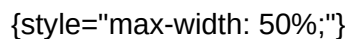
Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/being-a-great-remote-manager.md

What is remote management?

{style="max-width: 50%;"}


Similar to leading a team in-person, a remote manager must set up effective technology, communication, and workflows for their remote employees. Many traits found in onsite managers are also found in managers of colocated teams, though there are nuances to serving, leading, and guiding when managing teams that you do not see in-person each day.

Traits of a great remote manager

{{< youtube "S197ok0lBtw?start=431" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the topic of cultural maturity during an interview with Mårten Mickos, CEO of HackerOne.

Managing remotely is much like managing in-person, but there are certain traits of outsized importance for the former.

Self-awareness

Self-awareness is critical for relationship building and trust, particularly in an all-remote setting. The reality is that people prefer to learn, and to be managed, differently. GitLab's CEO goes so far as to publicize his communication preferences[</handbook/ceo/>], which requires a high degree of self-awareness, a low level of shame, and a penchant for transparency.

Self-aware managers will be open with reports on their learning and communication preferences, enabling those who report to them to interact without ambiguity.

Be highly sensitive to micromanaging. Particularly for new remote managers, you may be inclined to "check in" on projects with increased frequency given the inability to see someone working in the same physical space. This is a destructive practice. Instead, have an open discussion with a direct report on communication and work styles, and find a mechanism that suits all parties.

What a manager perceives as proactively working to keep a project on track can be received as

toxic micromanagement by a direct report. Without an open channel to communicate preferences, this can quickly erode a working relationship.

Empathy

Empathy and kindness are core to being a great remote manager. It can be challenging to put yourself in the shoes of a direct report using text communication and Zoom calls. In-person interactions allow for body language to be more easily read. In a remote setting, managers must instead be proactive in asking direct reports how life is going and what their learning preferences are.

GitLab gives people agency and trusts each team member to embrace ownership, and act as a manager of one.

For a greater understanding of the importance of empathy in a manager, read GitLab's guide to combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety.

Servant-leader

Working to have no ego, recognizing that people are not their work, and having short toes will go a long way to building trust as a manager. The humility required to be a servant-leader is rare, and is of great importance in a remote setting. Particularly for reports who are acclimating to their first remote role, managers may need to go above and beyond to lead by example.

In many cases, reports will be discovering in real-time how they prefer to be managed remotely. Maintaining the perspective that managers excel by serving is critical to building confidence in a direct report.

People tend to feel more guilty about asking a manager for step-by-step guidance in a remote setting · e.g. "I'm bothering them in their home!" To proactively address this, be sure to reinforce that you (as a manager) are not bothered by sincere requests for assistance.

In sum, remote managers should operate from a standpoint of wanting others to succeed. In the event that critical feedback must be delivered, strive to surface issues constructively and do so in a 1-1 setting.

Detailed

Managers are often stretched for time. A critical, though common, mistake is to assume that you can earn back time by not communicating in full to one's direct reports. Great remote managers will devote time to writing things down. GitLab's handbook-first approach to documentation encourages managers to contextualize thoughts in text.

Transmitting expectations, updates, and feedback through text is highly respectful. It enables a direct report to ingest information at their own pace, and it removes margin for misinterpretation. Written words are more easily questioned, thereby creating a more direct path to absolute truth and understanding.

Builds Trust

To be a successful leader of remote teams, one must develop a level of trust in each team. A trustworthy leader of remote teams consistently provides feedback to enable team members to feel included, valued, empowered, and respected.

A remote leader must be intuitive and able to adapt to the preferences of their direct reports. Some team members prefer more or less communication from their leader, some need consistent affirmation, others prefer autonomy. The ability to ask about and adapt to these preferences is crucial. Many of these elements are viewed as unspoken needs in other organizations, but great leaders seek to clarify and remove ambiguity. This is a key element of servant leadership.

Being a remote manager means building a support system for your team, while at the same time striking a balance to hold them accountable. Building trust and maintaining transparency, frequent and open communication, and ensuring a safe working environment are critical skills.

Use weekly 1-1 meetings to discuss business topics, challenges, and focus areas to build trust. Managers can supplement formal meetings with coffee chats where no business is discussed. Listening and sharing during these discussions can facilitate more open conversations. Consider structuring team meetings with a social component where team members can share the personal side of themselves.

Tips for being a great remote manager

Be visible and approachable

Not everyone is capable of going fully-remote or mentally prepared to go days without a human interaction. Set up regular video chats and be sure to make space for intentional informal communication.

Being a remote manager means building a support system for your team, while at the same time striking a balance to hold them accountable. Building trust, maintaining transparency, communicating frequently and openly, and ensuring a supportive working environment are critical for success.

Maintain constant communication

At GitLab, Slack is critical to our communication with each other. While it enables real-time communication, we also are careful to remain true to our asynchronous mindset, suggesting that GitLab team-members set "do not disturb" and not expect real-time answers from others all the time.

Prioritize one-on-one time

Don't underestimate a 1:1. Asynchronous communication (e.g., via text) is helpful and necessary. In some cases (e.g., to clarify misunderstandings) it can be much more effective to jump on a Zoom video call. Schedule regular Ask Me Anything (AMA) meetings so team members can meet a new leader, learn more about an existing team member, or gain clarity on a recent change.

Challenge thinking, not schedules

All-remote settings empower team members to live and work where they're most fulfilled. Implementing asynchronous workflows increases efficiency and decreases dysfunction. Increasingly, operating asynchronously is necessary even in colocated companies which have team members on various floors or offices, especially when multiple time zones are involved. All-remote settings are more inclusive; for example, they provide flexibility to childcare providers who are combining work with parental responsibilities. Async work also removes time zone bias, enabling global team members to be on equal footing.

Delegate

As teams grapple with transitioning from a colocated environment to a remote one, it's common to see differing levels of adaptability. For some, the transition is fairly smooth, as a remote-first infrastructure was already established. For others, the shift is thoroughly disruptive.

The amount of disruption is generally tied to two maturity factors: culture and tools. It's important to perfect the art of the handoff. To better understand how to delegate well, move your team through these phases of remote adaptation.

Use great apps

There is an endless and ever-changing list of options available for online collaboration. Here are a few tried and true apps and online tools to get you started on your async journey:

- Google Drive
- Slack
- Loom
- GitLab
- Tettra
- Slab
- Asana
- Monday.com
- Twist

Want to see how GitLab does it? Here's our tool stack.

Promote inclusion

So long as your company adheres · even if unofficially · to set working hours, you'll be biased towards candidates who are in your preferred time zone.

The only way to remove that bias and open your company to a truly global and diverse workforce is to destroy the epicenter of power as it relates to working hours.

This also enables your workforce to design their work around their life, empowering them to be managers of one. This is a more inclusive and healthier way of working.

Make it fun

Informal communication complements in-person interactions and matters in an all-remote culture.

Here's our list of more than 20 ways to encourage a happy, healthy informal work culture.

Stay lighthearted

Informal communication is important, as it enables friendships to form at work related to matters other than work. Those who feel they have genuine friends at work are more likely to enjoy their job, perform at a high level, feel invested in the company, and serve others within the organization. At GitLab, we desire those outcomes as well, reinforcing our Results value.

For all-remote companies, leaders should not expect informal communication to happen naturally. There are no hallways for team members to cross paths in, no carpools to the office, etc.

> If you do all-remote, do it early, do it completely, and change your work methods to accommodate it. Be intentional about informal communication. All-remote forces you to do the things you should be doing anyway, earlier. - GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij

In an all-remote environment, informal communication should be formally addressed. Leaders should organize informal communication, and to whatever degree possible, design an atmosphere where team members all over the globe feel comfortable reaching out to anyone to converse about topics unrelated to work.

Encourage social interactions

It's natural that working remotely leads to mostly work-related conversations with fellow team members, so everyone at GitLab is encouraged to dedicate a few hours a week to having social calls with anyone in the company.

It's a great chance to get to know who you work with, talk about everyday things and share a coffee, tea, or your favorite beverage. We want you to make friends and build relationships with the people you work with to create a more comfortable, well-rounded environment.

Prioritize onboarding

{style="max-width: 50%;"}

Onboarding is critical in equipping a new report with the tools and understanding they need to thrive at a company. A manager must be intentional about setting up guardrails to ensure that onboarding is not derailed. This is enabled through a long-term mindset. The depth and thoroughness of onboarding · as well as how much onboarding a new hire is cleared to complete · is linked to long-term success.

There is always work to be done, and a manager must make a conscious decision to allow a new hire to focus on onboarding instead of work during the critical early weeks, believing that in doing so, they are enabling long-term efficiencies and prioritizing that over short-term task elimination.

Numerous studies have shown that most employers rank poorly in onboarding quality, despite realities that losing an employee to poor onboarding is not cheap and a strong onboarding process boosts new hire retention and productivity.

Select the right Onboarding Buddy

GitLab's use of Onboarding Buddies is critical to the overall success of onboarding.

The manager should be intentional about selecting an onboarding buddy. Aim to select an onboarding buddy that complements the new hire. For example, if the new hire is inexperienced in GitLab, consider selecting an onboarding buddy who is proficient in using and teaching GitLab. If the new hire has never worked remotely before, consider selecting an onboarding buddy with a history of working remotely.

Balance self-learning and nurturing

In a remote setting, it's vital that a new hire recognize the importance of working handbook-first. This reality needs to be balanced with nurturing · an empathetic approach to working with a colleague. During onboarding, ask for feedback on this. A manager should be willing and able to adapt to a new hire's preferred communication methods, and be willing to iterate on this.

How do you motivate remote workers?

Some best practices for motivating remote teams include:

- Prioritize impact over activity
- Don't require people to have consistent set working hours or say when they're working
- Don't encourage or celebrate working long hours or on weekends
- Encourage teamwork
- Say thank you often

How do you manage remote workers?

GitLab's expertise in managing a remote team has been turned into a free course on Coursera!

"How to Manage a Remote Team" provides a holistic, in-depth analysis of remote team structures, phases of adaptation, and best practices for managers, leaders, and human resources professionals. It is being offered free of charge, with an optional paid certificate available.

Red flags to watch out for

Despite its many advantages, all-remote work isn't for everyone. It can have disadvantages for potential employees depending on their lifestyle and work preferences, as well as the organization. In the spirit of transparency, we'll also highlight counterpoints and solutions to these challenges.

Loneliness and isolation

The first month in a remote role can feel lonely, especially if you're transitioning from a traditional office setting.

- To prevent loneliness, all-remote companies should consider an intentional structure to informal communications.

- Scheduling coffee chats, social calls, and incentivizing in-person visits between team members are several of the ways in which GitLab accomplishes this.

Feeling left out

Remote settings can cause a breakdown in communication skills if organizations aren't deliberate about creating ways for their people to stay connected.

- All-remote companies should default to asynchronous communication to combat feelings of being left out of important discussions.
- We welcome all-remote companies to glean from GitLab's approach to meetings, as well as our scheduled AMAs, group conversations, and Key Reviews that are open to all.

Overworking

It can be hard to separate personal and work life. It's important to model and encourage boundaries.

- Preventing a culture of burnout starts at the top. In all-remote companies, it's important to reinforce this from the interview process, to onboarding, to regular 1:1s.
 - All-remote companies should consider putting focus on impact (as opposed to activity). Fundamentally, this requires organizational trust · believing that colleagues will do the right thing rather than implementing rigid rules.
 - At GitLab, we encourage team members to communicate with their manager when they recognize burnout, and to be mindful of the last time a team member took time off from work.

1. Remote work requires you to manage your own time and be self-motivated, disciplined, and organized.

The importance of video chats

Not only do we get to know our coworkers better by seeing them in real time during video chats or Zoom calls, we also get to know their pets and families too. This visual engagement helps us relate to each other on a more personal level, so when we meet in person, we already know each other. In fact, when our team members meet face-to-face for the first time, the most surprising factor is usually each person's height.

Manage process

{{< youtube "SP7u0gYCHiY?start=608" >}}

In the video above, Darren Murph, Head of Remote at GitLab sits down with Jeff Frick for a Digital CUBE Conversation about the way the global Covid-19 crisis is affecting the way people work, and work from home. Discover more in GitLab's Remote Work playlist.

A natural inclination when managing a team is to manage people · the individuals. In a remote setting, consider focusing management efforts first on process. GitLab operates handbook-first, which is to say that everything which can be documented is documented.

To better understand how this impacts management style, consider this example. Each time a

manager is asked a question by a direct report, there is a loss of productivity and focus in answering. If this answer is delivered verbally and privately, its benefit is highly specific and ephemeral. If, however, the manager considers the answer, documents it in a searchable location, and answers with a link, the process of answering becomes far more useful long-term.

In the latter case, this act of managing a process instead of a person creates outsized long-term efficiency. Every future direct report who has the same question will now be able to side-step the interruption and locate the answer themselves, creating two positive loops in the process.

One, new hires recognize that they are empowered to search for answers, securing important information to keep projects moving even when their manager is on vacation, out of the office, or engaged in other work. This should lead to fewer blockers, less dysfunction, greater autonomy, improved mental health, and greater productivity.

Two, managers carve out more bandwidth in their day to focus, rather than re-answering questions.

Document solutions

It is the job of a manager to ensure a direct report has what they need to be successful on an ongoing basis. By documenting processes, guides, solutions, how-tos, and policies, a manager is practicing servant leadership in a powerful way.

If your company has yet to implement their own handbook, start now and start small. Don't be overwhelmed with the notion of building a complete handbook from the get-go; simply start with one process, then document the next, and so on. This is the power of iteration. GitLab (the company) uses GitLab (the product) to build and maintain our public-facing handbook, and options from other companies are available as well.

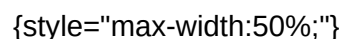
In the event that a direct report asks a question that has yet to be documented, agree to document the eventual solution so that the work put forth in answering benefits a wider swath of people.

By embracing a documentarian mindset as a manager, you show that you are proactively and transparently working to equip your direct report(s) with everything they need to succeed.

This may feel as if it's placing an added burden on a manager. The reality is that short-term pangs derived from time spent on documenting will be greatly overshadowed by long-term efficiencies. If you, as a manager, believe that you "simply don't have time to document," pause and consider the current scenario from a perspective involving more than yourself.

If you don't have time to do it right, when will you find time to do it over?

Lean on a mentor

{style="max-width:50%;"}


Even for those who have managed colocated teams for decades, the thought of managing teams

which are distributed globally can be daunting. Managing remotely is a skill that can be taught and learned, and much of what is gleaned through colocated management experience can guide one's journey through remote management.

For those new to managing remotely, consider shadowing someone with experience and establishing a mentor-mentee relationship.

If you feel comfortable with the softer skills, pay close attention to the processes used by remote managers. For example, you can't walk by a report's desk and get a feel for how things are going, so many remote managers utilize an ongoing Google Doc agenda (or a dedicated tool, such as Soapbox or Fellow) where notes, blockers, etc. can be chronicled. Checking a living, evolving document as a mechanism for engagement may require building a new habit.

Discuss learning preferences

{style="max-width:50%;"}

Learning is personal. Not only does it vary from person to person, but it can vary from project to project. It's important to understand the breadth of learning styles, and have continual conversations that take this into account. Many managers will ask their reports to take a personality test, or ask what their preference learning style is, during the first week working together. Unfortunately, that exploration typically ends there.

Remote managers should view this as a perpetual item for discussion. As the relationship evolves, skills are built, and experiences are gained, it's possible that one's preferred style will shift.

Managers of global teams should also anticipate a variety of styles to be represented in their team. This encourages diversity, and it requires a manager to be cognizant of what style they're interacting with when bouncing between conversations. In a colocated space, reports may flex their style to more closely align with people they are in physical proximity to.

Focus on career progression

{style="max-width:50%;"}

A common concern of remote workers is the perceived inability to further their career while outside of an office. This is often seen in hybrid-remote companies, where remote employees may wonder if team members who commute into the office will be better positioned for raises and promotion opportunities.

Great remote managers will proactively ask about one's career goals, and frequently discuss how a report is moving towards a particular career objective.

Research from Headlamp shows that 82% of workers said they would be more engaged in their work if their managers regularly discussed their career aspirations but only 16% of employees reported having those conversations on a regular basis. By having regular conversations about career advancement with your remote team, you can build a more connected and engaged workforce.

GitLab favors more frequent conversations on this topic · even during routine 1-1 conversations · as opposed to waiting until an annual review cycle.

Remove roadblocks to improve productivity

In a global all-remote organization, driving results is a core value. As a manager, you have to keep many balls in the air simultaneously and shift your energy and attention to activities that will produce the greatest output (also known as "managerial leverage"). Removing roadblocks to improve productivity is a key skill set of any remote manager. Great managers will delegate activities while giving team members the full picture, encourage others to work according to GitLab's values, and set their direct reports up for success.

To improve managerial productivity:

1. Create feedback mechanisms for team members to understand what they are doing well and what could be improved.
1. Develop incentives that benefit the team and individuals.
1. Craft training mechanisms for leaders and continuously improve tools to help the team achieve results.
1. Prioritize tasks and have a clear expectation of what everyone is working on with due dates.
1. Use GitLab Issues and Merge Requests to track work.

With GitLab's commitment to transparency, team members have a great deal of visibility to what is going on throughout the organization. A manager's role is to focus the team on cross-functional activities relevant to their results.

How to engage remote employees

Good communication is the key to keeping your employees in the loop. Here are a few best practices to keep your team engaged:

- Encourage people to write down all information
- Allow everyone in the company to view and edit every document
- Consider every document a draft, don't wait to share until it's done
- Use screenshots in an issue tracker instead of a whiteboard, ensuring that everyone at any time can follow the thought process
- Encourage non-work related communication for relationship building
- Encourage group video calls for bonding
- Encourage one-on-one video calls between people (as part of onboarding)
- Host periodic summits with the whole company to get to know each other in an informal setting

How to keep a remote team connected

Transparency helps keep your team connected to the work and each other. Some best practices on working transparently include:

- Be open about as many things as possible. By making information public we can reduce the threshold to contribution and make collaboration easier. Use public issue trackers, projects, and repositories when possible.
- An example is the public repository of our website that also contains our company handbook.

Everything we do is public by default, for example, the GitLab CE and GitLab EE issue trackers, but also marketing and infrastructure.

- Transparency creates awareness for GitLab, which allows us to recruit people that care about our values. It gets us more and faster feedback from people outside the company, and makes it easier to collaborate with them. It's also about sharing great software, documentation, examples, lessons, and processes with the whole community and world in the spirit of open source, which we believe creates more value than it captures.

Managing non-remote team members

In an all-remote environment, where every single member works outside of a centralized company office, you won't be put in a situation where a remote manager must manage a non-remote team member.

However, it is conceivable that a remote leader would manage a colocated third-party team. For example, a remote public relations (PR) manager overseeing a colocated agency team on contract. In hybrid-remote companies, this scenario is more common, as a subset of the company commutes into a physical office while others work remotely.

This arrangement is best addressed when colocated members adopt remote-first communication and workflow practices. Managing these teams may require additional coaching to use tools like Zoom and Slack in place of in-person communication, even if it feels unnatural, in order to treat everyone as equally as possible.

For example, if you're leading a synchronous meeting with colocated reports, ask that each person use their own webcam and microphone, and that all documented discussion occur in a shared document.

Contribute your lessons

We believe that remote managers can learn from one another, and direct reports who admire their remote manager can inform others on how to manage well. If you have an anecdote, tip, or experience to share that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

— — —

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/building-culture.md

On this page, we're detailing how to build, communicate, and reinforce a sustainable culture in a remote environment.

What is company culture?

```
{style="max-width: 50%;"}

```


Culture is the barometer of how well values are adhered to and reinforced in an organization. Therefore, culture can only be maintained if values are prescriptively articulated and visibly reinforced through elements such as discretionary bonuses and linking promotions to values.

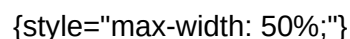
In a colocated setting, culture is typically formed through tacit or implicit knowledge. In a healthy remote work environment, the building blocks of culture are documented transparently, making them accessible to everyone.

If you want to build a great culture, start with your company's core values. You should be able to hand your values to someone who doesn't work at your organization and they be so well-articulated that person would understand how to treat you and your colleagues. Ideally, your values are public so that others can contribute their own knowledge and experiences.

Why is company culture essential for remote work?

It takes intentionality to build a company culture in a company that has no offices. While technology and tools are enabling companies to operate efficiently in a remote setting, it's important to focus on creating a great culture first, then using tools to support it.

How do you create a remote culture?

{style="max-width: 50%;"}


"How do you build and sustain culture in a remote environment?" or "How does culture work remotely?" are questions we frequently hear at GitLab. In colocated settings, culture is often implied, built from how team members treat one another, what is rewarded, what is chided, and what is deemed acceptable during in-person interactions.

In colocated companies, it's easy to let culture be shaped by office decor, the neighborhood in which a company's headquarters is located, or the loudest voice in the room. Not only is this dangerous · one's culture can oscillate based on external factors · but it's not a usable strategy in a remote environment.

In a remote team, there's no office vibe, hip coffee, or Spotify playlists that decide the culture, which is a gift. Instead, culture is written down. Culture is equal to the values you write down, and what you do as a leadership team to reinforce those values.

It starts by being intentional about informal communication.

{{< youtube "IU2nTj6NSIQ" >}}

In the video above, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the topic of scaling culture during an interview with Stuart Miniman, host of theCUBE and GM of Content at SiliconANGLE Media.

It's challenging to build and maintain a healthy remote culture. Despite its advantages, all-remote work isn't for everyone. It can have disadvantages as well. In the spirit of transparency, here are some of the challenges and solutions to maintaining remote work culture.

Culture looks different in a pandemic

Do not conflate forced work-from-home during a pandemic with cultural degradation due to working in a remote environment.

Many companies forced into remote by external factors such as COVID-19 are recognizing that, in general, employees are not as happy. This creates a response question: "How do you maintain culture in a suddenly-remote environment?"

That is a valid question, but it masks the actual question: "How do you maintain culture in any work environment during a global pandemic?"

In a period of tremendous external stress, culture is less about workplace rah-rah and more about intentionally reallocating that energy to serve society. Leaders must accept that the benchmark has changed. Expecting employees and managers to maintain a pre-crisis level of cheer during a pandemic can further deflate morale, and refusing to acknowledge this reality will make it more difficult for culture to recover post-crisis.

Even a company's culture champions, the most enthusiastic of team members, are under unprecedented duress during a global crisis. Many are struggling to work while doubling as a homeschool teacher, or concerned about the well-being of neighbors and community members. The energy they once allotted to championing workplace culture is being used up elsewhere, rightly prioritized to focus on new stressors in life outside of work. Complicating matters further is that few employees are willing to state this for fear of being penalized for taking their focus away from work, and not living up to expectations. It is essential for leadership to proactively take steps to create a non-judgmental culture.

Rather than assuming that workplace culture is eroding, consider showcasing how people in your organization are using their energy to support others outside of the workplace. Hearing stories of colleagues supporting first-line workers, neighbors, and community members will bolster morale at work. Being open about taking time away from work to be there for others who are struggling in the midst of a pandemic will create even stronger bonds at work.

Reimagining the post-pandemic workforce

GitLab's Remote Work Report sheds light on the current reality of remote work.

In 2021, we learned that 86% of respondents believe remote work is the future, and 62% of respondents said that they would consider leaving a co-located company for a remote role. Contrary to popular belief, we found that most remote workers aren't digital nomads, and 52% are actually likely to travel less than their office working counterparts.

As leaders and team members were grappling with going remote, the pandemic forced many into quick adoption. The Remote Work Report provides insights on what matters to those who adopt remote work and charts a path for building culture around autonomy and flexibility.

Why inclusion matters more than ever

GitLab believes that combining many perspectives creates a more innovative environment to work in, with more satisfied teammates, leading to a better product and increased profitability. Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging is one of our company values.

Inclusion allows us to recognize, respect, and value differences in those around us. Being inclusive requires skills such as empathy, openness, and listening. Inclusion also means we are keenly aware of both positive and negative biases and how those biases impact our daily interactions, work, and employee retention.

Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging is fundamental to the success of GitLab as a remote organization. We include it in every way possible and in all that we do.

Seven tips to promote inclusion in a remote workforce

1. Be empathetic

Empathy and kindness are core to being a great remote manager. It can be challenging to put yourself in the shoes of a direct report using text communication and Zoom calls. In-person interactions allow for body language to be more easily read. In a remote setting, managers must instead be proactive in asking direct reports how life is going and what their learning preferences are.

GitLab gives people agency and trusts each team member to embrace ownership, and act as a manager of one.

For a greater understanding of the importance of empathy in a manager, read GitLab's guide to combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety.

2. Ask about needs, listen, then act

Don't underestimate a 1:1. Regularly schedule video calls to check in and ask how you can help remove roadblocks. Set up Ask Me Anything (AMA) meetings so team members can meet a new leader, learn more about an existing team member, or gain clarity on project or a recent change.

3. Dedicate time for networking and team building activities

Working remotely leads to mostly work-related conversations with fellow team members, so everyone at GitLab is encouraged to dedicate a few hours a week to having social calls with anyone in the company.

It's a great chance to get to know who you work with, talk about everyday things and share a coffee, tea, or your favorite beverage. We want you to make friends and build relationships with the people you work with to create a more comfortable, well-rounded environment.

4. Normalize challenging personal assumptions

To achieve results, team members must constantly · collaborate and work together effectively. At GitLab, helping others is a priority, even when it is not immediately related to the goals that you are trying to achieve. Similarly, you can rely on others for help and advice·in fact, you're expected to do so.

Anyone can chime in on any subject, including people who don't work at GitLab. Collaboration means providing an effective framework for challenging directly and delivering feedback.

5. Encourage participation within a diverse space

Both formal and informal communication in-person interactions matters in an all-remote culture. Here's our list of more than 20 different ways to encourage a happy, healthy informal work culture.

6. Proactively develop and mentor all team members based on their individual requirements

Mentor relationships are an opportunity for individuals to learn from someone's personal experience, background, and perspective. Mentorships help build trust, provide safe space to make mistakes, and encourage both personal and professional development.

Mentorship is an opportunity for both the mentor and mentee to develop their leadership and communication skills and should be led by the mentee, similar to how 1:1's at GitLab are driven by direct reports.

7. Create inclusion commitments among remote team staff

Diversity, inclusion and belonging are fundamental to the success of GitLab. We aim to foster an environment where everyone can thrive. We are designing a multidimensional approach to ensure that GitLab is a place where people from every background and circumstance feel like they belong and can contribute. We actively chose to build and institutionalize a culture that is inclusive and supports all team members equally in the process of achieving their professional goals.

One way to create inclusion among your remote staff is to remove time zone bias via asynchronous communication.

Take initiative to operate asynchronously whenever possible. This shows care and consideration for those who may not be in the same time zone, are traveling outside of their usual time zone, or are structuring their day around pressing personal or local commitments.

For example, you can record and share team meetings using GitLab Issues and Merge Requests rather than sending texts, calls, or Slack messages. Be aware of local holidays, personal vacation statuses, and encourage others to default to documentation rather than pressuring team members to be online outside of their working hours.

How do I assess culture fit remotely?

For hiring teams, a common challenge is this: "How do I assess culture fit remotely?"

To answer this question, you first need to unlearn a bit, and change your frame of mind. A hiring manager should not aspire to assess culture fit. Rather, you should aspire to assess values fit.

For many, it is assumed that culture is simply the aura, energy, or vibe one gets when walking into an office. This is largely driven by decor and personas in the room. It is dangerous to allow company culture to be dictated by such factors, as this will create an oscillating culture that changes depending on mood or socioeconomic conditions.

A company culture is a company's list of values. Culture is an assurance that each employee respects, admires, and feels invested in a company's values, and that leadership works to ensure values are not violated. As GitLab, an operating principle within our Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging value is "culture fit is a bad excuse."

Remote interviewers should link a company's values during the interview and have a conversation to assess a candidate's alignment and understanding of those values. Particularly in a remote setting, values serve as the north star, guiding every business decision by people you cannot physically see and shaping how colleagues treat one another.

No unwritten rules in a remote work culture

{style="max-width: 50%;"}

There should be no unwritten rules in remote culture. Intentional documentation is essential to avoiding dysfunction within a remote company, and this also applies to culture. At GitLab, this begins with our company values: Collaboration, Results, Efficiency, Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging, Iteration, and Transparency.

Culture is best defined not by how a company or team acts when all is well; rather, by the behaviors shown during times of crisis or duress.

Intentional onboarding

A team member's first experience with company culture is unavoidable. The onboarding experience serves as the first post-interview encounter with culture, and it is essential to infuse the importance of values into that experience.

Remote onboarding should set aside time for a new team member to read and digest a company's values, which serve as a company roadmap to culture. Consider having a mentor or onboarding buddy specifically ask questions related to values, providing opportunity for the new team member to dive deeper into how they are lived day-to-day.

Using GitLab for remote onboarding

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at [GitLab's remote team solutions page](#).

Reinforcing your values

Whatever behavior you reward will become your values. New hires and promotions serve as important decisions to promote and reinforce values. GitLab reinforces its values by what:

1. Leadership does.

1. We select for during hiring.
1. We emphasize during onboarding.
1. Behavior we give each-other 360 feedback on.
1. Behavior we compliment.
1. Criteria we use for discretionary bonuses.
1. Criteria we use for our annual compensation review.
1. Criteria we use for promotions.
1. Criteria we use to manage underperformance.
1. We do when we let people go.
1. We give value awards for during Contribute.

In negative feedback, one should be specific about what the problem is. For example, saying someone is "not living the values" isn't helpful.

Never take company culture for granted

While the importance of culture is driven home during onboarding, continual reinforcement is required to keep it top-of-mind. In the course of business, it's easy to lose sight of values and culture when focusing on OKRs and KPIs. However, it is vital for leadership to remind themselves and other team members that values should never be pushed aside or lowered in priority.

Every decision a business makes should align with their values. Otherwise, values will be seen as "merely words," and culture will disintegrate.

If your company gets all team members together on a regular basis, consider resurfacing values or providing opportunities for groups to live out those values through community service. Just as certain trainings are recommended or required each year as part of a company's ongoing learning and development efforts, reminding team members of values is vital to sustaining a strong culture.

How to sustain your organization's culture when everyone is remote

A healthy remote work environment clearly defines its culture and expectations. These written definitions enable team members to exemplify the organization's values regardless of their physical location.

Embrace transparency in all interactions

Be open about as many things as possible by making information public. This transparency helps reduce confusion and makes collaboration easier. Use public issue trackers, projects, and repositories when possible.

Transparency creates awareness for GitLab. It does that by allowing us to recruit people that care about our values, gets us more and faster feedback from people outside the company, and makes it easier to collaborate with them. It also helps us share great software, documentation, examples, lessons, and processes in the spirit of open source, which we believe creates more value than it captures.

Continually promote and enhance work-life balance and flexibility

From family time to travel plans, there are many examples and stories of how remote work has enhanced the lives of GitLab team members.

> "The flexibility makes family life exponentially easier, which reduces stress and makes you more productive and motivated. You can't put a dollar value on it · it's priceless." - Haydn, Regional Sales Director, GitLab

The freedom and flexibility that comes with all-remote enables employees to view work in an entirely new light.

Rather than forcing a predefined daily schedule replete with a commute, all-remote shifts allows an individual to define their schedule.

A number of studies by organizations such as Google, Buffer, FlexJobs, and IWG show that driven individuals who place a high degree of value on autonomy and flexibility can experience new levels of joy and productivity in an all-remote environment.

Address employee well-being and mental health issues

Remote and asynchronous work can help alleviate stress and support mental health.

{{< youtube "IU2nTj6NSIQ?start=621" >}}

In this video, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the mental health benefits of asynchronous communication.

Expectations to be online, available, and responsive during set working hours can be stressful. Our hyper-connected society has allowed this notion to seep into every hour of the day, blurring or destroying the boundaries between work time and personal time.

One benefit to working asynchronously is a reduction of tension. When your entire company operates with an understanding that any team member could be offline at any time, for any reason, there is no expectation for immediate replies.

This creates an environment where your mental health is prioritized, allowing team members to set boundaries and freeing them from a perpetual assault of notifications and judgment.

The importance of gratitude and transparency

Persistent negativity can erode culture. While feedback is a gift, there's a fine line between reacting with hope and determination when facing a challenge and allowing a sense of apathy or dread to permeate a company. Leaders should be cognizant of this and act swiftly if there's a noted drop in outward gratitude or transparency in communications.

{{< youtube "cy6WGuzArgY?start=232" >}}

Emna G., founder and CEO at Veamly, spoke with GitLab's Darren M. on how she fosters and sustains a thriving culture within a remote-first company.

> Every Monday, we get everyone on a Zoom call for something we call "Gratitude Monday."

Everyone shares what they're grateful for. It doesn't have to be work-related. The idea is to live by gratitude; we need to learn how to embrace it.

>

> Some Mondays, you've had a bad weekend or you've woken up on the wrong foot. For me, I try to push my team to take a moment, pause, and really feel it. We see the difference when we remember what we're grateful for.

>

> We also do "Meditation Wednesdays," where we get on a Zoom call and we do breathing exercises. Then we share what we're stressed about, and what we're looking forward to. The idea is that it's OK to be stressed · we're human · but we want to balance that stress and create empathy.

Spotlight remote-work culture ambassadors

A remote culture is only as strong as it is lived. At GitLab, we encourage team members to surface culture on a regular basis through the following mechanisms.

1. Say Thanks

1. Use values emoji · · to recognize messages that exemplify a company value.

1. Recommend a colleague for a discretionary bonus. If granted, the rationale and values lived are then documented and announced during a company call, serving as a beacon to others on how to improve the lives of others by living the values.

1. Serving as a GitLab Contribute Ambassador, which helps the entire company get the most out of a weeklong trip to spend time with each other in person every 9-12 months.

1. Everyone can contribute to strengthening GitLab's values by creating merge requests and fostering discussion.

Put structure around culture

It may sound counterintuitive, but there is great value in putting process and structure around culture. For example, if a company has an unlimited vacation policy, but has no suggestions or process around it, you may create a culture of fear with regard to taking time off.

{{< youtube "cy6WGuzArgY?start=1021" >}}

Emna G., founder and CEO at Veamly, spoke with GitLab's Darren M. on the importance of process in building remote culture.

> Put process around things. Studies show that when a company has unlimited vacation, people don't take vacation.

>

> It's important to be communicative about the minimum that needs to be taken. It's also important to be clear on the structure. If you give a team something without structural limits, they really